International Yoga Day. As recalled by Asoke Mukerji, who led the Indian diplomatic campaign for the adoption of the resolution at the time, this task was defined as a “priority” for Indian diplomacy.[45] Emphasising that India was “working not just for a better future for ourselves, but for the whole world,” the proposal was tabled under “global health and foreign policy” to resonate with the Prime Minister’s rationale that yoga is not simply about exercise, but about “discovering the oneness within ourselves, the world and nature.”[46] In the expansive Indian understanding, it could even benefit multilateral initiatives like the Sustainable Development Goals and clime change negotiations.[47]

The resolution was supported by a majority of states, had 177 co-sponsors, and was formally adopted less than three months later. Ambassador Mukerji attributes this feat to the “conscious application of the methods and objectives of strategic ‘inclusive’ diplomacy by India.”[48] Commenting on the achievement at the United Nations, the then External Affairs Minister Sushma Swaraj contextualised it within a larger diplomatic strategy:

> while on one hand, we consistently advocate a proactive and innovative approach for making India and the greater South Asian region more prosperous, at the same time, we are thinking and acting on new measures to project India’s soft power – the unparalleled cultural richness, diversity and uniqueness of India and its people.[49]

Building on the success of the UN’s designation of the International Yoga Day, United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) has declared yoga a “world treasure” and recognised the practice as an Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. This not only provides better visibility for it at the international level but